

Montparnasse

Working title for the recast of Richard Triberg's 220-page Exposé "*The Extraordinary Life & Times of the Immortal yet Forgotten KIKI, Queen of Montparnasse*" into a literary memoir of the dig.

What this is

A creative brief for a book. The book is **the four-year journey** Richard Triberg has been on with the Modigliani — *Sitting Nude with Crossed Hands*, c. 1917, 40.5 × 33 cm, currently at Institut Restellini Analyses Scientifiques in the Geneva Freeport — written in a voice that does justice both to the painting and to the man who has been walking with it for fifty-two months.

It is not a replacement for the Exposé. The Exposé is the body of evidence. This is the **literary spine** that carries the evidence — what a reader who is not in the art world can pick up at a bookstore, sit with for a weekend, and put down changed.

The premise in one paragraph

In 2022 Richard Triberg of Pacific Arts Collection meets Bill {____}, a Modigliani specialist quietly working on a small canvas held by two collectors in Bratislava. Bill has 5,000 hours into the painting and no name for the sitter. He thinks it is Kiki. The catalogue raisonné does not know it exists. Bill takes Richard in. Three years later Bill dies and Richard inherits the work. Four years after his first phone call with Bill, Richard is on a private jet from Prague to Le Bourget on the eighteenth of March, 2026, with the painting in a crate beside him and the CERN-derived forensic lab director Jiri Lauterkranc next to him, and the painting is now in Geneva under particle physics, and Marc Restellini's signature is still wet on the Mission Order, and nobody yet knows what Marc is going to write. **The book is the four years.**

The narrator's voice — the stack

Five literary voices layered. None of them is louder than the others. The narrator (Richard) sounds like none of them by themselves and like all of them together.

Layer	Role	Where you feel it
Holden Caulfield	The spine. Every sentence in Richard's mouth.	Default register. The deflection, the self-correction, the refusal of the academic move, the conversational confiding.
Hunter S. Thompson	The fuse.	Late-night Richard. The Prague chapter. The Antwerp dead end. Anywhere Richard is on his fifth coffee and his second wrong decision.
Indiana Jones / Da Vinci Code	The action engine.	Every modern chapter has the same skeleton — wrong city, missed plane, door that won't open, artifact in hand. With one discipline: nothing happens that could not really happen. No conspiracy, no guns. The stakes are professional, financial, art-historical, personal. The chase is across real archives.
Hemingway	A character. He wrote the foreword to Kiki's 1928 memoir.	Chapter VIII. A presence in others. He is a person, not a stylistic model.
Fitzgerald	The wallpaper of Circa Montparnasse.	Every period vignette. Third-person, present tense, the rooms come alive. Never in Richard's mouth.

The dual structure

Every chapter does the same move. Richard in the present holding a piece of evidence, the prose dissolves into the 1920s scene that evidence illuminates, the prose returns to Richard putting the evidence down. **The fade-in trigger is always a specific verifiable fact about *this* canvas** — a pigment chromatograph, a stretcher mark, a 1925 ledger entry, a single sentence in the Prague court file. Never a general fact about Modigliani or Kiki. The fact has to earn the doorway.

[Richard, present day, Holden voice]

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[CIRCA MONTPARNASSE, [season] [year]
Fitzgerald wallpaper, present tense,
the cast in real rooms]

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[Richard physically does something —

closes the notebook, gets off the metro,
hangs up the phone – and we're back]

The buddy — Camille Aubry

Every story needs a partner. We invent one. Camille Aubry, senior scientist at Institut Restellini's Geneva lab, reporting to Xavier Pellaud, runs the actual X-ray microfluorescence and pigment chromatography on the painting. Late thirties, French, École Normale Supérieure chemistry, eight years at Restellini. The one person who knows the file better than Marc does, because she ran the data.

She is Richard's exact opposite. He is intuition, narrative, literary archaeology. She is pure data, refuses to speculate past the chromatograph, calm, two espressos a day, leaves the lab at six. They argue. They drink. He explains a Hemingway letter, she explains a calcium-carbonate ratio, they walk to a café on a wet Thursday in Geneva. The chapter where they finally have the same answer is the chapter where the book turns. The book ends on her phone call to Richard with the verdict — not Marc's email. **What stays with the reader is the two of them on the phone, whether Marc signed or not.**

Camille is the **one** invented character in a modern cast of real people. She is fictional precisely so the buddy-cop structure has somewhere to live without putting words in any real person's mouth.

The cast — modern timeline

Name	Role
Richard Triberg	The narrator. Pacific Arts Collection, North Richmond, CA.
Bill {____}	The late mentor. 3-year association, 5,000+ hours, dies before authentication. His estate is in the commission chain.
Camille Aubry	The buddy. Restellini senior scientist, Geneva. Fictional.
Marc Restellini	The authority. The man whose signature is the whole game.
Xavier Pellaud	Camille's boss. Mission Order signatory.
Alba Berti	Marc's assistant. The door-opener. Loyal to Marc.
Mirek {____}	Czech intermediary. Commission chain.
Alexander + Judr. Robert	The Slovak owners. Bratislava. English is not perfect.

Name	Role
Jiri Lauterkranc	InsightART co-founder. CERN robots.
Dr. Otto M. Urban	DOX Centre curator, Prague. 90-day evaluation.

The cast — Circa Montparnasse, 1922–1929

The Flapper-age Rat Pack. All in the same 600-metre radius around the Carrefour Vavin at the same time.

The painters — Kiki de Montparnasse · the ghost of Modigliani (dead January 1920, his absence shapes the whole period) · Jeanne Hébuterne · **C.R.W. Nevinson** (shared a studio with Modi in 1917 — Richard's red-pillow discovery) · Picasso · Foujita · Soutine · Chagall · Brancusi · Calder · Marie Vassilieff · Lempicka · Lee Miller · Suzanne Valadon · Utrillo

The writers — Hemingway · Hadley then Pauline · F. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald · Stein and Toklas · Joyce · Sylvia Beach · Djuna Barnes · Natalie Barney · Anaïs Nin · Pound · McAlmon

The lens — Man Ray · Berenice Abbott · Brassai · Kertész

The night — Josephine Baker · Sidney Bechet · Cole Porter · Bricktop · Mistinguett

The movement makers — Cocteau · Tzara · Breton · Satie · Dalí · the Dadaists turning Surrealist

The thesis Richard is writing toward (never states out loud)

The wreckage was the same. Loss, addiction, obsession, sex. Modigliani drank himself to death. Jeanne killed herself. Zelda burned alive in an institution. Hemingway put a shotgun in his mouth. Kiki died alone of cirrhosis in 1953, the queen having become an inconvenience.

But while they were there, they **sat together**. They ate together. They looked at each other across small tables. They argued and slept with each other and read each other's pages out loud. The pain was the same. The connection was above the pain. *That is what we have lost*. That is what Richard is grieving without ever quite saying so. The reader figures it out somewhere around Chapter Seven and walks around quietly with it for a week.

The historical backdrop

The cafés are not just cafés. The cafés are the first cafés in human history where the people in them have telephones, cars, electric light, jazz on the wireless, cinema down the boulevard, aviation overhead, and brothers buried at Verdun. The wild ride has teeth.

- **1918–1920:** 20M dead in the Great War. 50M dead in the Spanish flu. Modi dies January 1920, lungs already gone.
 - **The franc collapses** — Americans live like kings on small dollars. Prohibition pushes the literary class to Paris.
 - **Industrial revolution accelerates** — 3,000 cars in France in 1919, 1.4M by 1928. Telephones, electricity in homes, cinema, radio, aviation. Modernity in its infancy.
 - **Black American jazz musicians** find work and dignity in Paris that they cannot find in Chicago.
 - **The over-indulgence has teeth** — Modi at 35, Soutine at 50, Fitzgerald at 44, Hemingway at 61, Kiki at 51. All of them died of the same wound.
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The twelve-chapter spine

#	Title	Modern (Richard)	Circa Montparnasse
0	Prologue	—	Europe, 1918–1922 — the world the cast walks into
I	Bill	The phone call. The three-year association begins.	1917, Modigliani's studio on Rue de la Grande Chaumière
II	The Red Pillow	Richard recognises a red cushion in a 1917 Nevinson — the 109-year-old shared-studio discovery	1917, the shared studio. Nevinson one side, Modi the other
III	The Forensic File	First meeting with Camille at the Geneva Freeport. The CERN robots.	1917, Modi mixing the pigments
IV	Bill Dies	The mentor is gone. Richard inherits the work. The heaviest Holden chapter.	(silent — modern only)
V	Mirek and the Slovaks	Bratislava. Alexander, Judr. Robert. English is not perfect.	1917, the sitter. The crossed hands.

#	Title	Modern (Richard)	Circa Montparnasse
VI	The Wildenstein Letter, 2012	Marc was the Wildenstein curator the first time the painting passed through Paris. Camille finds the 2012 file.	1917 substance, 2012 framing
VII	Alba	Phone calls, cover letter, the door opening. The corridor friction between Alba and Camille.	1917, Kiki sent from Châtillon-sur-Seine to Paris by her mother
VIII	Marc	The face-to-face. The professional sparring. The seventh-volume catalogue raisonné conversation.	1917, the Berthe Weill nude exhibition shut down by the police
IX	March 18, 2026 — The Private Jet	The painting flies Prague → Le Bourget → Geneva. Camille meets the jet on the tarmac. The longest conversation in the book.	1917, the painting being painted, in real time, the room cold
X	The Geneva Freeport	The painting under particle physics. Camille's home court.	1917, finished. Drying on the easel. Modi has 32 months left.
XI	Four Days in Montparnasse	Richard walks the streets alone in March 2026. The Sélect, the Rotonde, the Dôme, the cabarets. The thesis lands.	1922–1929, the full Flapper-age Rat Pack at full burn, as Richard walks
XII	The Certificate	Marc signs or does not sign. Camille calls Richard with the verdict — not Marc's email. The book ends on the phone call.	The final vignette: Kiki dying alone in a hospital ward, 1953

About 90,000 words. A real book. The last chapter is **currently being written by the actual world**. Marc has not yet signed. We do not know how it ends. Neither does Richard. Neither does the reader, until the reader gets there. That is the Indiana Jones tension nobody has to invent.

Three sample passages — to lock the voice

A. Holden opener, Chapter I

If you really want to know about it, I bought the magazine on the Rue de Buci on a Thursday in October, which I shouldn't have been on the Rue de Buci at all that day because I was supposed to be on a plane to Tel Aviv looking at a different set of papers that turned out to be fakes anyway, but the plane got cancelled, and I had four hours before the rebook, and the rebook was one of those things you don't want to think about until you absolutely have to. So I walked. I walked down to

Saint-Germain and across to the Rue de Buci, and there was a guy with a folding table and a stack of old magazines, and he reminded me of someone, and the rest of this book is what happened.

B. Circa Montparnasse vignette, autumn 1924

CIRCA MONTPARNASSE, AUTUMN 1924

The Dôme is full at eleven and emptying by midnight, and the Coupole has not been built yet so the overflow walks down to the Rotonde or up to the Sélect. She is twenty-three. She has been calling herself Kiki for four years. The Modigliani has been dead nearly five.

*Hemingway is at the bar. He is twenty-five and tall, and his wife is at home with a baby they cannot afford, and he does not know that the story he will write about all of this, twenty-five years later in Idaho with a shotgun in the next room, will be called *A Moveable Feast*.*

*Fitzgerald is across the room with Zelda. Zelda is dancing alone. Zelda is going to be dancing alone for years and then she is going to be in an institution in Asheville, and the institution is going to catch fire in 1948 and she is going to die in it, but tonight she is twenty-four and dancing alone, and Scott is watching her dance, and the part of him that is going to write *Tender is the Night* is already taking notes.*

Man Ray is at the corner table with a Leica. He is waiting. He waits for Kiki most nights.

She crosses to the bar. Hemingway turns. He does not say anything. He never says anything to her in any of the accounts. He just turns.

C. Thompson register, Prague 2024

I should not have flown to Prague that week, and I have spent the years since wondering why I did, and the answer I keep arriving at is the only honest one, which is that I had not slept in forty-one hours, I had drunk eight espressos across three cities since the flight from Rome, and I had a Czech court registrar's name written on the back of a Lufthansa boarding pass and a window of seventy-two hours before the case file went back into a vault in a basement on Národní třída that I was not, technically, supposed to know existed.

The taxi from Václav Havel was driven by a man who did not believe I was a journalist, which I was not, because I told him I was an art historian, which I also was not. He thought I was a buyer. Everybody in Prague that week thought I was a buyer.

Working title

Montparnasse *Richard Triberg*

One word. The book is in the word. No subtitle. The cover is the word and the name. Inside, every period chapter wears **CIRCA MONTPARNASSE** as a museum placard.

What is already done

- Richard's **220-page Exposé** is the substrate. We are recasting, not starting from scratch.
- Seven **Breakout Reports** are the citable forensic / provenance / biographical evidence.
- The **Brokerage Agreement** (4 March 2026), **Restellini Mission Order**, and **NVAI Update #4** are the documents that establish the modern timeline.
- The painting is **at Restellini, in Geneva, right now**. Marc has not yet signed.

What I need from Richard to start the work

1. **The 220-page Exposé** — the Dropbox link or the PDF directly. Nothing new gets drafted until I have read every word he has already written.
2. **A blessing on Camille Aubry as the buddy** — fictional composite, Restellini scientist, life modern-timeline only.
3. **A blessing on the dual-timeline structure** — the fade in / fade out around verifiable forensic facts, every chapter.

What happens after

1. **Read the 220-page Exposé** in full.
2. **Map** existing chapters to the 12-chapter spine. Identify passages worth preserving verbatim. Identify the dual-timeline opportunities already implicit.
3. **Build the Scrivener manuscript** — research drawer holding the Reports and the three transaction documents, cast drawer with one card per historical figure and one per modern figure.

4. **Draft Chapter II — The Red Pillow** — as the fade-mechanism proof chapter. ~6,500 words. If this chapter sings, every other chapter is the same trick.
 5. **Wire /atelier into NVAI** — long-form publication home for the book, chapter-by-chapter serialised release behind the Modigliani painting page.
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Drafted for Richard Triberg on behalf of NVAI. The painting is in Geneva. The book is in the room. The signature is pending.